Tata Steel project that never took off. "The erroneous concept of development has posed a threat to the rights of tribals over their *jal*, *jangal* and *zameen* [water, forests and land]," Baghel said at the festival. He also told the media recently that his government will move the Supreme Court to increase reservation for tribals as per their population. On November 9, he sent a proposal to the assembly Speaker to hold a special session next month over the issue.

In another significant step, the state government wrote to the Union environment ministry on October 31, seeking cancellation of the approval given to the Rajasthan Rajya Vidyut Utpadan Nigam Ltd for non-forestry use of 841.54 hectares of land in the Parsa Coal Block of Hasdeo Arand forest. It stated that the continuing protests around it could become a law and order issue. Notably, the Baghel government cleared the land for use in April after Rajasthan chief minister Ashok Gehlot met his Chhattisgarh counterpart to discuss pending approvals.

WHY TRIBAL VOTES MATTER

Of the 90 seats in the state assembly, 29 are reserved for ST candidates. Currently, the Congress holds all 14 segments in north Chhattisgarh and 12 in south Chhattisgarh, where tribal votes are significant. In total, the party has 27 of the total ST-reserved seats, against the 18 it had won in 2013.

Thus, even as both the Congress and the BJP focus on OBC outreach nationally, the criticality of tribal votes in Chhattisgarh is clear as day. The BJP seems to be eyeing a comeback in north Chhattisgarh, riding on Hindutva issues. Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) chief Mohan Bhagwat will be in Jashpur on November 14 to unveil the bust of late BJP leader Dilip Singh Judeo. The programme is likely to reignite the subject of religious conversions as Judeo was widely known for his 'ghar wapsi' campaigns in the state. Structurally as well, the BJP recently effected changes in its state unit and inducted new faces to improve its poll prospects.

Amid such high stakes, the dance festival was perhaps just a glimpse of the politics around tribal votes, which may only grow more intense as both parties pull out their best moves. ■

BIHAR

CHIRAG BURNS BRIGHT



SECOND COMING
Chirag campaigning for the BJP in the bypolls

By Amitabh Srivastava

Chirag Paswan turned 40 on October 31, and one of the first people to call to wish him was Union home minister Amit Shah. But greetings aside, Shah's call was also seen as a thank you gesture since the Lok Janshakti Party (LJP) leader had the day before announced his support to the BJP candidates for the November 3 bypolls in Bihar. As it happened, it turned out to be crucial as the BJP won one of the two assembly seats on offer, Gopalganj, in what was its first test of strength after Chief Minister Nitish Kumar and his Janata Dal (United) dumped them in August.

The fact that Shah reached out to Chirag also conveyed a larger message—the late Ram Vilas Paswan's son was back in favour with the BJP's top leadership. A sword now hangs over Union minister Pashupati Paras, Chirag's estranged uncle who split the party, for he may have outlived his utility for the saffron party. Soon enough, Paswan Jr's Twitter handle was flooded with birthday wishes from BJP leaders in Bihar. At the political level, it almost formalised the BJP-Chirag alliance for the 2024 Lok Sabha election.

The deal is also a lifeline for Chirag, as he had been floundering for a while. The BJP too found itself without partners, pitted now against a formidable alliance of the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) of Lalu Prasad Yadav and Nitish's JD(U). Bihar is crucial for the BJP's 2024 ambitions as it sends 40 Lok Sabha MPs to Parliament. On November 6, the bypoll results saw the RJD (Mokama) and BJP retain their seats. Chirag had campaigned for the BJP, and his influence was clear. Gopalganj has a good number of Dalit voters, especially Paswans, who it seems voted for the BJP.

Shah reaching out conveyed a larger point—Chirag was back in favour with the BJP

Life indeed has come full circle for Chirag. After the run-ins with Nitish, being abandoned by the BJP, uncle Paras splitting the party and taking five of six MPs with him, it seemed his stock had hit rock bottom this March when he was evicted from the 12, Janpath bungalow allotted to his late father in Delhi. But everything changed after Nitish exited the NDA. Though Chirag leads just a splinter LJP group, many see him as the real inheritor of Paswan Sr's legacy (the 5-6 per cent Paswan vote in Bihar). Dalits account for 15-16 per cent of Bihar's vote but are not a homogenous block as there is little unity among the 22 sub-castes in the category. Which is where Chirag could prove useful—the Paswan voters are believed to be a "transferrable lot".

With the bypoll win and Chirag's re-entry, the BJP seems to have made a good start in rebuilding an alliance in Bihar for 2024. Chirag, of course, is in a win-win situation, though how much he can contribute to the saffron cause remains to be seen. ■